

## BM2 — Lesson 2: Hannah

Barren but Not Lifeless

 **Theme: Prayer in the Pain**

 **Background Text:** 1 Samuel 1–2

 **Key Verse:** 1 Samuel 1:27 (WEB)

“I prayed for this child, and Yahweh has given me my petition which I asked of him.”

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### Introduction

Elkanah was a Jewish man with two wives. In that culture, although love was part of why you married, having children was a major factor. Many times, barren women ended up divorced or pushed to the margins of society. Peninnah and Hannah were his wives, but Hannah could not have children.

Have you ever felt like you were “stuck” in someone else’s shadow? Like no matter what you did, the other person always seemed to be one step ahead? That was Hannah’s situation. Year after year, she was humiliated and reminded how much of a “failure” she was as a wife because she could not give Elkanah an heir.

At least her husband loved her, right? It didn’t feel that way. The voice of her tormentor cut deeply, and it seemed as if her prayers were bouncing off the ceiling.

### **Reflection(s)**

Write down a memory of when you felt like the world kept you in its shadow. How have you dealt (or been dealing) with this situation?

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### Appetizer – The Weight of Waiting, 1 Samuel 1:7–8 (WEB)

“So year by year, when she went up to Yahweh’s house, her rival provoked her; therefore she wept, and didn’t eat. Elkanah her husband said to her, ‘Hannah, why do you weep? Why don’t you eat? Why is your heart grieved? Am I not better to you than ten sons?’”

In Jewish culture, having children is everything. If a man did not have a child, even if he was a scholar, he was not given the same honor. Their cultural and ethnic code weighed heavily on Hannah's mind. Her husband had every right, culturally, to divorce her and marry someone else. Inheritance and family legacy were tied to children.

In today's terms, Hannah showed signs of deep depression and grief. She felt that no one around her really understood or could comfort her. She stopped eating, cried endlessly, and felt useless.

If you or someone you know is going through something similar, there is help available. You do not have to battle alone—reach out to your church family, a community counselor, or a trusted friend.

 **CST: Desperation can drive determination.**

How does persistent prayer reshape hopelessness into hope?

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## Main Course

### Bite 1 – Provoked but Persistent, 1 Samuel 1:9–10 (WEB)

“So Hannah rose up after they had eaten in Shiloh, and after they had drunk. Now Eli the priest was sitting on his seat by the doorpost of Yahweh's temple. She was in bitterness of soul, and prayed to Yahweh, and wept bitterly.”

What do you do when you are really going through it? Who is the best person to turn to who can *truly* help? Many times, we go first to people who can listen—but cannot change anything. Hannah's womb was “lifeless,” but she took her lifelessness to the Living God.

 **CST: Pulse Check**

Have you ever found yourself crying out to God from that dark place? Take a moment to write a prayer request—personal or for your family—that you want the Lord to work out.

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## Bite 2 – Prayer that Breaks Barrenness 1 Samuel 1:12–15 (WEB)

“As she continued praying before Yahweh, Eli observed her mouth. Now Hannah spoke in her heart; only her lips moved, but her voice was not heard. Therefore Eli thought she was drunk. Eli said to her, ‘How long will you be drunk? Get rid of your wine!’ Hannah answered, ‘No, my lord, I am a woman of a sorrowful spirit. I have drunk neither wine nor strong drink, but I poured out my soul before Yahweh.’”

A When you are at your lowest, even "religious" people might misjudge your struggle. But Hannah didn't let a man's mistake stop her from talking to her Maker. God hears the prayers that are too deep for words. God is our Promise Keeper, but sometimes *we* make promises to Him and then break them. If that has ever happened in your life, be honest with God.

### Reflections:

Why is it important that we take these acts seriously? Can you think of examples of when people give or make vows (marriage, baptism, oaths, commitments)?

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## Bite 3 – Promise Fulfilled and Faith Honored, 1 Samuel 1:15–18 (WEB)

“Hannah answered, ‘No, my lord, I am a woman of a sorrowful spirit. I have drunk neither wine nor strong drink, but I poured out my soul before Yahweh. Don’t consider your servant a wicked woman; for I have been speaking out of the abundance of my complaint and my provocation.’ Then Eli answered, ‘Go in peace; and may the God of Israel grant your petition that you have asked of him.’ She said, ‘Let your servant find favor in your sight.’ So the woman went her way, and ate; and her facial expression wasn’t sad any more.”

It is OK to correct a false narrative. Allow your virtue and truth to shine even in dark situations. Eventually, God remembered Hannah. She conceived and gave birth to Samuel, and later brought him back to serve the Lord, just as she had vowed (1 Samuel 1:19–28).

### CST: Answered prayer often requires releasing what we prayed for.

Can you trust God enough to give back the blessing He gave you—time, talent, or even a person?

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## Dessert – The Song of Victory, 1 Samuel 2:1–2 (WEB)

“Hannah prayed, and said, ‘My heart exults in Yahweh! My horn is exalted in Yahweh. My mouth is enlarged over my enemies, because I rejoice in your salvation. There is no one as holy as Yahweh, for there is no one besides you, nor is there any rock like our God.’”

### Reflection:

True praise flows from answered pain. Hannah’s song came from a place of long weeping and finally, breakthrough.

What song has your victory written for you? (It could be an actual song, a testimony, or a phrase you hold onto.)

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### To-Go Box

Hannah’s story proves that barrenness—physical, emotional, or spiritual—is never the final word.

- Faith speaks life into empty places.
- Honest prayers, poured out from a broken heart, reach God’s ears.
- When God fills what was empty, the best response is to give the glory, and even the gift, back to Him.

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### Closing Prayer

“Lord, thank You for Hannah’s story and for reminding us that You hear the cries we pray in secret. Teach us to pour out our hearts honestly before You, to honor the vows we make, and to trust You with both our pain and our promises.

Where we feel barren or empty, speak life.

Where we have been misunderstood, let Your understanding surround us.

And when You answer, help us to give the glory—and even the blessing—back to You.

In Jesus’ name, amen.”

**AB CD** Activity – Word Scramble: Hannah’s Hope

Unscramble each word to reveal key truths from the lesson. (*Hints in parentheses*)

1. **NNAHHA** (her name) \_\_\_\_\_
2. **ULSAME** (the son she bore) \_\_\_\_\_
3. **ETARP** (what she did earnestly) \_\_\_\_\_
4. **THEFAI** (what God rewarded) \_\_\_\_\_
5. **LIHEFSI** (2 words, what she gave back to God) \_\_\_\_\_

**Multiple Choice /Fill in the Blank**

1. Elkanah was married to \_\_\_\_\_.  
a. Hannah and Peninnah  
b. Hannah and Phinehas  
c. Hophni and Peninnah  
d. None of the above  
Answer.
2. Elkanah and his wives would go to sacrifice in \_\_\_\_\_ at the Lord of \_\_\_\_\_.  
a. Judah, Heaven’s Armies  
b. Judah, Heaven’s Angries  
c. Shiloh, Heaven’s Armies  
d. Shiloh, Heaven’s Angries  
Answer.
3. A vow is a \_\_\_\_\_.
4. Hannah promised to never \_\_\_\_\_.  
(a) Fight Peninnah  
(b) Cut her child’s hair  
(c) Lie again  
(d) Come to the temple drunk  
Answer.

5. “Seeing her lips \_\_\_\_\_ but hearing no \_\_\_\_\_, he thought she had been \_\_\_\_\_.”

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(Check appendix for answers.)

 **Notes Page — Group Discussion & Personal Study**

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